



BEFORE

Faith in a spiritual dimension to human existence probably evolved separately in many parts of the world among bands of Paleolithic hunter-gatherers.

ANIMISM

The earliest belief of the hunter-gatherers is known as animism. In animism, all of **physical nature has a spiritual counterpart** and everything becomes part of a chain. Each object, living or inanimate, is a link, but the links



GREEK GOD ZEUS

are fluid so that a man can become a bird, an animal can be disguised as a rock, and a bird can transform into a cloud. The power for these changes stems from a world of vaguely defined guardian spirits.

MANY GODS

As tribes became settled into farming communities, pantheons of more **clearly identifiable gods** emerged. Each god was responsible for overseeing

a part of the temporal world, and still acting as the guardian of his or her domain—such as Zeus, the Greek god of thunder and lightning and also the ruler of Mount Olympus. This is **polytheism** (meaning “many gods”) **◀ 142–43**, which early Christians dubbed “paganism,” a derogatory term from the Latin *pagani*, meaning “peasants.”

THE NEXT WORLD

The belief in an afterlife may extend back even farther in time than animism, because **Neanderthal** **◀ 19**

burial sites sometimes included medicinal herbs and other items, which could suggest that they thought the deceased was embarking on a **journey to another place.**

PANTHEISM A doctrine or belief presenting the natural world, including humankind, as being part of the divine. It is the predominant belief in Hinduism, but is rejected by beliefs that hold that God is transcendent—a being above the created world—such as Christianity and Islam.

